

THE QUIETEST KID IN THE KINGDOM

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*A bedtime story about the loud, brave magic
of a quiet heart.*

MK PARRISH

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

The world is very good at noticing the loud ones.

The child who shoots her hand up first. The one who fills the room. The one who is picked, and cheered, and seen from across a crowded square. And in all that noise, it is easy for a quieter child to decide that quiet must mean *less* — less brave, less special, less important.

This is a story to put that idea to bed.

It is about a girl named Posy, who almost never spoke, and who turned out to be holding the one thing the whole loud kingdom had lost. Read it softly. And when it ends, tell the quiet child beside you what took the kingdom a whole story to learn: *the quiet ones are not empty. They are full. They are just listening.*



THE QUIETEST KID IN THE KINGDOM

In a kingdom that loved to be loud, there lived a girl named Posy, and Posy was the quietest kid anyone had ever met.

It was a kingdom of noise, and it was proud of it. There were trumpets at breakfast and drums at lunch and, at every festival, a great contest to see who could cheer the loudest. The children shouted their answers and sang at the top of their lungs and told long, loud stories about themselves in the square. And Posy — Posy sat at the back, and watched, and said almost nothing at all.

"Speak up, Posy!" the teachers would say. "Don't be shy!"

But Posy wasn't shy, exactly. She just didn't see the point of saying a thing until it was worth saying. So while the other children filled the air with words, Posy filled herself with something else. She listened. She noticed. She heard the sparrow that sang a half-beat behind all the others. She saw which children were laughing and which were only pretending. She knew the sound the wind made just before the rain, and the exact look on her mother's face that meant *I am tired but I don't want you to worry*. Posy collected all of it, quietly, the way some children collect shells.

"She's so quiet," the townspeople would say, a little worried. "You never know what she's thinking."

That was true. They never did. It never once occurred to them to sit down beside her and find out.

Now, the loudest thing in all the kingdom was the Great Bell.

The Great Bell hung in the tower at the center of town, and its ring was so enormous, so magnificent, that it could be heard in every corner of the land. It rang for festivals and weddings and the crowning of kings. The whole kingdom loved it. The whole kingdom was, in a way, built around it — the loudest sound for the loudest people.

And one grey morning, the Great Bell went silent.

The bell-ringer pulled the rope, and instead of the enormous, magnificent ring, there came only a dull, cracked *thunk*. He pulled again. *Thunk*. The Great Bell was broken, somewhere deep inside, and no one could tell where.

The kingdom panicked. The finest craftsmen climbed the tower and looked at the enormous bell and scratched their heads. "The crack could be anywhere," they said. "It's the size of a house. We would have to take the whole thing apart, piece by piece, and that would take a year." The mayor wrung his hands. A festival was coming. A kingdom without its bell! It was unthinkable.

The craftsmen shouted suggestions at each other. The crowd shouted suggestions at the craftsmen. The square got louder and louder, as it always did, everyone certain that the

answer was *more noise, more talking, more shouting over each other.*

And at the very back of the crowd, a small quiet voice said, "I know where the crack is."

Nobody heard it. It was, after all, a very loud square.

So Posy did something that cost her more courage than any of the shouting children would ever understand. She walked to the front. She tugged the mayor's sleeve. And when he bent down, she said it again, just to him, in her small and certain voice:

"I know where the crack is."

The mayor frowned. "How could *you* know? The finest craftsmen in the kingdom don't know."

"Because they were talking," said Posy. "And I was listening." She looked up at the tower. "When the bell-ringer pulls the rope, it doesn't go *thunk* all at once. There's a tiny sound first — a little hiss, like a whisper — up near the top, on the left side, where the sun hits in the morning. I've heard it for weeks. It's been getting louder. That's where it's breaking. You don't have to take the whole bell apart. You just have to look there."

The square went quiet — really quiet, maybe for the first time in its history.

The craftsmen climbed the tower. They went to the top, on the left side, where the sun hits in the morning. And there, so fine you could barely see it, was a hairline crack — right where the quietest kid in the kingdom said it would be.

They mended it in a single afternoon.

That evening, the bell-ringer pulled the rope, and the Great Bell rang out enormous and magnificent over the whole land, and the entire kingdom cheered — the loudest cheer in the loudest kingdom there ever was.

And in the middle of all that glorious noise, the mayor did something he had never thought to do before. He crouched down next to the small girl at the edge of the crowd, and he did not tell her to speak up. He said, gently, "Posy. I think we owe you an apology. We spent all these years telling you to be louder. And it turns out the kingdom didn't need another loud voice. It needed someone who was finally listening."

Posy smiled. She didn't say much. She rarely did.

But from that day on, when something important went wrong — a lost child, a quarrel nobody could untangle, a sound in the night that turned out to matter — the kingdom learned to do a brand-new thing.

They got quiet. And they went and found Posy.

Because the loudest kingdom in the world had finally learned the secret the quiet girl had known all along: you cannot hear anything true while you are shouting.

Sometimes the bravest, most powerful thing a person can do is simply, carefully, listen.



THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

The world will spend a lot of your childhood telling you to speak up.

And sometimes that's good advice. But sometimes — more often than the loud world admits — the most valuable person in the room is the quiet one. The one who isn't busy talking. The one who is *noticing*. The one who hears the hairline crack while everyone else is cheering.

If you are a Posy, please hear this, even though it's written softly. Your quiet is not a thing to be fixed. It is not shyness, and it is not emptiness. It is a kind of listening the loud world has forgotten how to do, and one day it will matter more than all their noise combined.

You do not have to become the loudest to become the one who saves the day.

You just have to keep listening — and be brave enough, when it truly counts, to walk to the front and say the quiet, certain thing you alone have heard.

The kingdom is waiting to find out what you know.



*This is a tale from **The Little Rewrites** — bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after, exactly as they are. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups, are waiting at **mkparrish.com**.*

NOTES

